

For phones, there are two card formats: microSD (accepted by all phones except Sony Ericsson) and M2 (works only in Sony Ericsson phones). But, now Sony Ericsson phones are also moving towards microSD. miniSD is an old format that is not used any longer.

Talking about the market size of memory cards, microSD is the highest selling category at the moment, largely because of growing sales of mobile phones. About 100 million mobile phones were sold last year in India alone. In comparison, sales of digital cameras are much lower. SD cards come next in market size. These are used in most cameras now. CompactFlash is a slightly older and very specific technology.

As regards the size, microSD are the smallest and available in capacities of up to 32 GB. SD cards are bigger than microSD and available up to 64 GB. CompactFlash are the biggest in size. These too are available with up to 64GB capacity.

Talking of price, if you compare 2GB cards, which are the highest selling cards, microSD are the cheapest and CompactFlash the most expensive.

CompactFlash cards are the size of the matchbox and used for industrial applications (as these are much more rugged) and cameras. These can support 3.3V and 5V operation and switch between the two, in contrast to other small-form-factor flash memory cards that can operate only at one voltage.

Memory Sticks, patented by Sony, are exclusive to Sony products. These are light, compact and designed for a wide variety of devices including digital cameras and recorders. With the use of an adaptor, most Sony Memory Sticks can be used with almost all Memory Stick PRO compatible products. Both PRO Duo and PRO-HG (HX) variants of Memory Stick support up to 16 GB.

MMCs are used in different kinds of devices. These are the size of a stamp.

Memory cards vs USB flash drives and portable HDDs

1. Memory cards are very portable and have a huge capacity in a small size.
2. Memory cards are easy to carry and compatible with most of the system software, whereas flash drives at times have to be formatted to be made ready to use.
3. Memory cards are generally inserted into the device and left there. Due to this, there are lesser chances of misplacing or damaging the memory cards. In case of flash drive or portable hard disk (HDD), the drive has to be inserted time and again and carried separately. This means there is chance of the drive getting damaged or misplaced.
4. Memory cards, depending on the version, can be used in multiple devices, which is not possible with flash drives or portable hard drives.
5. Form factor: Memory card: 15×11×1.4 mm³; USB drive: 40×20×10 mm³; portable HDD: 91×72×15 mm³

When you add some encryption/cryptographic information to MMCs, these become SD cards. So SD cards are an enhancement of MMCs. These have a lock mechanism that prevents overwriting of data. So when you don't want your files to be copied, SD cards are more useful.

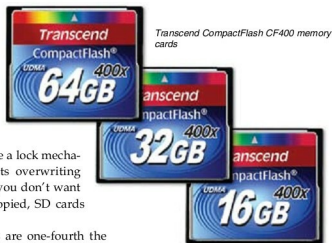
microSD cards are one-fourth the size of standard SD cards. While SD cards are compatible with photography gadgets, microSD cards are compatible with multimedia-enabled mobile phones.

SDHC are high-capacity microSD cards. Any card that becomes more than 4 GB, is SDHC. SDHC format is slightly different from SD. If the reader in your device/computer doesn't have SDHC logo, it can't support 4 GB and above card. The maximum capacity of microSD is 2 GB, while microSDHC supports up to 32 GB.

2GB and 4GB are the most common card capacities.

Is there a single card for camera as well as mobile?

There is no one card that can go both into a cellphone and a camera. However, you can do so by using an adaptor. While it is less likely that you can use your digital camera card on your mobile phone, it is indeed possible to



do the reverse, i.e., to use your mobile phone card onto your digital camera. Essentially, a smaller card (microSD) can be changed into a bigger card using an adaptor but a bigger card cannot be turned into a smaller card.

The adaptors are usually locally made products and available for as less as Rs 30 in the Nehru Place market in New Delhi. Use of adaptor with microSD, however, is not recommended as there are always more chances of error due to dual connectors in use. The speed of the resulting SD card will be lower than the actual SD card; microSD cards are meant for phones, not cameras. Also, it's not practical to keep shifting the card from one device to another for saving such a small cost.

Things to look for

While buying a memory card for a device, make sure that the card is